

ZOKARIO EDITIONS

Slow Cities

*Essays on travelling at the speed of noticing:
eleven cities, unhurried.*

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Lisbon, on Foot

I missed the tram on purpose on the third morning, which is the exact moment the trip began. The 28 is a beautiful tram and everyone should ride it once, ideally at seven before the queue outnumbers the city. But a tram is a sentence read aloud at speed, and Lisbon is a book that wants you to move your lips.

On foot, the city reorganises itself around smaller units: the tiled doorway repainted in a slightly wrong blue, the grocer who stacks oranges like a man with opinions about oranges, the laundry line that crosses four centuries of architecture without asking permission of any of them. None of this is on the itinerary. All of it is the city.

By the second week I had a café where the coffee arrived without ordering, which is not a transaction; it is a minor citizenship. And I had learned Lisbon's first lesson, the one the hills teach your calves and the widows teach the afternoon: that arrival is not an event but a practice, and most of us leave three days before it happens.

This is a book about staying past that point. Eleven cities, no checklists, one method: walk until the city stops performing and starts living, then keep walking.

Kyoto at Bath-Time

The guidebooks send you to Kyoto's temples at dawn, and the guidebooks are right, and that is the problem: everyone holding the same book arrives at the same silence and evaporates it together. I found my Kyoto at the opposite end of the day, at the neighbourhood sentō, where the entire street goes at seven to sit in very hot water and say almost nothing.

You cannot photograph a public bath, which is precisely what saved it. Whatever a place forbids the camera, it keeps for the participants. An hour in that water taught me more about the city's actual texture than three days of shrines had: its codes of nearness and distance, its genius for shared solitude.

The old man who finally spoke to me asked one question: how long was I staying? A month, I said. He nodded at the water. 'Then you have time to come back tomorrow.' It was the entire philosophy of this book, issued from a bath.

E SSAY THREE

Naples Doesn't Care

Naples is the only city in this book that will not notice whether you visit, and there is a specific liberation in that. This essay is about travelling in places that refuse to perform, and about the best pizza of my life, eaten standing, watched by a dog with no interest in my enlightenment.

The remaining essays cross eight more cities before the last one turns for home, and asks what all this slowness is for.



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